hospitals apart from Covid vaccines in large numbers. I also had the opportunity to meet KP Sharma Oli, the then Prime Minister and Defence Minister of Nepal.

During the visit, I had, of course, met Gen Puran Chandra Thapa, the Nepali Army Chief. On one of the evenings, he hosted a reception for us, to which he had invited all the former Nepali Chiefs. While speaking with them, they all fondly remembered their visits to India and their Indian contemporaries. That gave birth to the idea that we should all get together—past and present Chiefs. In Sep 2022, I held the Chiefs' Conclave, a biannual event in which all the former Chiefs get together. In this conclave, non-classified issues and initiatives underway are discussed and the views of the former Chiefs are sought in light of the experiences they would have had while in service as well as post-retirement. Following up on the idea that I had, I invited all the former Nepali Chiefs on the last day of the Conclave. It was heartening to see how all of us immediately bonded, the years in between just melting away. This once again showed the strong Army-to-Army connect between the two countries. I also hosted Gen Thapa's successor, Gen Prabhu Ram Sharma, when he came to India, for his conferment of the rank of Honorary General of the Indian Army, and he recollected this get-together of the Chiefs. When the Nepali Army celebrated their Army Day in February 2023, Gen Sharma followed up by inviting all the former Indian Army Chiefs to join the celebrations. To honour the memory of Gen Bipin Rawat, they even installed a 'Bipin Bell' at the famous Muktinath Temple. Military diplomacy has a great role to play in cementing the relationship between countries and needs to be leveraged further.

The visits to the UAE and Saudi Arabia were the first-ever visits by an Indian Army Chief to either of these countries.

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